

High Performance Centre for badminton at Kalinga Stadium



'Shuttle by Dalmia Bharat' — a badminton High Performance Centre (HPC) - was inaugurated at the Kalinga Stadium Complex. This is a result of a collaboration between three parties, which was first initiated back in 2018.

If one goes to Jayadev Vihar in Bhubaneswar, signs that the 2023 Men's Hockey World Cup was held there will welcome them, including a mural of India captain Harmanpreet Singh.

In the vast Complex in the Odisha capital, there are centres dedicated to numerous sports in every direction. Now, badminton has got one of its own inside. The Dalmia Bharat Group, the Pullela Gopichand Badminton Academy, and the Government of Odisha signed a Memorandum of Understanding (MOU) five years back. The Covid-19 pandemic delayed the progress of the project, which has now culminated into the Dalmia Bharat Pullela Gopichand Badminton Academy.

"It's just not a beautiful building, but an aspiration for a lot of youngsters, to thousands across the country. It's a symbol of the badminton court and the shuttlecock that will help build champions," Gopichand, who is the current chief India coach, said at the inauguration ceremony.

Puneet Dalmia, Managing Director, Dalmia Bharat, spoke about India's impending bid for the 2036 Olympics and made a bold prediction. "I promise you that in the 2036 Olympics, one player from this academy will get one gold medal," Dalmia addressed Himanta Biswa Sarma, President, Badminton Association of India.

Sarma, who is also the Chief Minister of Assam, asked for more support for his shuttlers. "Every

sport like football and hockey gets support from the governments and the public. But our [badminton] players, despite the glory they bring, haven't got the sponsors and support they deserve. Badminton has a lot of potential. Like Odisha government is promoting hockey, I hope it also promotes badminton."

Also in attendance was Mohan Charan Majhi, the Chief Minister of Odisha. The 'Shuttle by Dalmia Bharat' is a seven-storey building which houses eight badminton courts, a seating arena around these courts which can accommodate 400

people, lodging facilities for 50 students, and a 360-degree view of the city and the Kalinga Stadium Complex from the seventh floor. The topmost floor also holds the lights, which when switched on after sunset, complete the building's shuttlecock-esque look. Moreover, the building has been made in a sustainable manner as low-carbon cement was used during construction. Rainwater harvesting for recharging groundwater is another feature of the structure that helps the environment.

Rajdeep Saha



Inauguration of the badminton High Performance Centre at the Kalinga Stadium in Bhubaneswar.

SPECIAL
ARRANGEMENT

SPORTOON

